

Note on *A course in Arithmetic* by J.P. Serre

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1 Chapter 1

This is a list of proofs of nontrivial results in Chapter 1 of *A course in Arithmetic* by J.P. Serre.

Let K be a finite field with q elements.

Theorem 1.1

Let u be an integer ≥ 0 . The sum

$$S(X^u) = \sum_{x \in K} x^u = \begin{cases} -1 & \text{if } u > 0 \text{ and } (q-1) \mid u \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

$u = 0$ is subtle here. We define $x^0 = 1$ for all $x \in K$ (this definition is nice when we work with polynomials because we can write 1 as x^0 to maintain symmetry), so $S(X^0) = q = 0$.

The proof is easy. Use primitive roots.

The variant proof: $x \mapsto x^u$ is a group homomorphism from $K^\times$ to itself. The kernel is all x such that x is a root of $x^{\gcd(u, q-1)} - 1$. So the image has size $\frac{q-1}{\gcd(u, q-1)}$, which implies the image is just the $d = \frac{q-1}{\gcd(u, q-1)}$ roots of unity. So the sum is 0 unless $d = 1$ (sum of d -th roots of unity is 0 if $d \geq 2$ is coprime to p).

Theorem 1.2 (Chevalley-Warning Theorem)

Let $P_1, \dots, P_r$ be polynomials in n variables over a finite field K of characteristic p . If the sum of their degrees is less than n , then the number of common solutions to the equations $P_1 = \dots = P_r = 0$ is divisible by p .

Proof. This uses a common trick in counting roots over finite fields. Consider the polynomial

$$Q = \prod_{i=1}^r (1 - P_i^{q-1})$$

The number of common solutions is equal to $\sum_{x \in K^n} Q(x)$ since if $P_i(x) = 0$ for all i , then $Q(x) = 1$, otherwise $Q(x) = 0$.

Expand this. For each monomial in the expansion $x_1^{u_1} \dots x_n^{u_n}$, since $\sum \deg(P_i)(q-1) < n(q-1)$, we have u_j is not divisible less than $q-1$ for some j . So by the previous theorem, the sum over K^n of this monomial is 0. (that's why we define $x^0 = 1$ above). So the number of common solutions is 0 mod p . $\square$

Corollary 1.3

All quadratic forms in at least 3 variables over a finite field have nontrivial zeros.

Theorem 1.4

$$\left(\frac{2}{p}\right) = (-1)^{\frac{p^2-1}{8}}$$

Proof. Let α be the primitive 8th root of unity α in $\overline{\mathbb{F}_p}$. Then, $y^2 = (\alpha + \alpha^{-1})^2 = 2$. If $p \equiv \pm 1 \pmod{8}$, then $y^p = y$, so 2 is a square in $\mathbb{F}_p$. If $p \equiv \pm 3 \pmod{8}$, then $y^p = -y$, so 2 is not a square in $\mathbb{F}_p$. $\square$

Theorem 1.5 (Law of Quadratic Reciprocity)

For two odd primes p and q , we have

$$\left(\frac{p}{q}\right) \left(\frac{q}{p}\right) = (-1)^{\frac{(p-1)(q-1)}{4}}$$

The key is to consider the Gauss sum: Let ζ be a primitive p -th root of unity in $\overline{\mathbb{F}_p}$, then define

$$y = \sum_{x \in \mathbb{F}_p} \left(\frac{x}{p}\right) \zeta^x$$

Then we have $y^2 = \left(\frac{-1}{p}\right) p = (-1)^{\frac{p-1}{2}} p$ and $y^{q-1} = \left(\frac{q}{p}\right)$. Combining these two gives the result.

2 Meeting 1 on Jan. 28 2026

This is a list of nontrivial results in the first meeting of the course.

Theorem 2.1

The finite subgroup of a field's multiplicative group is cyclic.

This can be easily proven using the structure theorem of finite abelian groups and the fundamental theorem of Algebra.

Definition 2.2. For any prime p or $p = \infty$, we define the

$$\|x\|_p = \begin{cases} p^{-v_p(x)} & p \text{ is a prime} \\ \|x\| & p = \infty \end{cases}$$

Theorem 2.3

For any rational number r , $\prod_p \|r\|_p = 1$

This is trivial from the definition of v_p .

We can in general define a norm on a number field K as follows:

Definition 2.4. $\|\cdot\| : K \rightarrow \mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}$ is a norm if

1. $\|x\| = 0$ iff $x = 0$
2. $\|xy\| = \|x\| \|y\|$
3. $\|x + y\| \leq \|x\| + \|y\|$

Corollary 2.5

$\|1\| = 1$ and $\|-1\| = 1$

Definition 2.6. Norm N_1 and N_2 are equivalent if there exists a real number c such that $N_2(x) = N_1(x)^c$ for all x .

Theorem 2.7 (Ostrowski's Theorem)

Any non-trivial norm on $\mathbb{Q}$ is equivalent to either the usual absolute value $\|\cdot\|_{\infty}$ or to $\|\cdot\|_p$ for some prime p .

Proof. We consider two cases:

Case 1: Assume $\|n\| \leq 1$ for all $n \in \mathbb{Z}$. If there exists n such that $\|n\| < 1$. Then there must be a prime p dividing n such that $\|p\| < 1$. We claim that p is the only prime such that $\|p\| < 1$. Let q be another prime such that $\|q\| < 1$. We can find N such that $\|p\|^N$ and $\|q\|^N$ are both less than $\frac{1}{2}$. By Bezout's lemma, we can find integers a, b such that $ap^N + bq^N = 1$. So $1 = \|1\| = \|ap^N + bq^N\| \leq \|a\| \|p\|^N + \|b\| \|q\|^N < \frac{\|a\| + \|b\|}{2} \leq 1$, which is a contradiction. So in this case, $\|\cdot\|$ is equivalent to $\|\cdot\|_p$.

The rest is sort of cumbersome. □

Theorem 2.8 (Hasse principle)

Example 2.9

$f(x, y, z) = 5x^2 + 7y^2 - 13z^2$. We want to find a nontrivial $f(x, y, z) = 0$ has non-trivial solutions in $\mathbb{Q}$ using Hensel's Lemma.

Consider this curve in $\mathbb{P}^3$, is there any other solution?

Use parameterization of this curve.

Theorem 2.10

If $n \geq 3$, $x^n + y^n = z^n$ has no non-trivial solutions in $\mathbb{C}[x]$.

Proof. Assume f, g, h are non-constant polynomials such that $f^n + g^n = h^n$. We further assume they $\max \deg(f), \deg(g), \deg(h)$ is minimal among all such triples. Therefore, $\gcd(f, g) = \gcd(g, h) = \gcd(h, f) = 1$. (otherwise, we can divide the common factor to get a smaller degree triple).

$f^n = h^n - g^n = \prod (h - \zeta^i g)$ where ζ is a primitive n -th root of unity. Notice that $\gcd(h - \zeta^i g, h - \zeta^j g) = \gcd(g, h)$ for $i \neq j$. So all $h - \zeta^i g$ are coprime to each other. Thus, $h - g = a^n$, $h - \zeta g = b^n$, $h - \zeta^2 g = c^n$ for some non-constant polynomials $a, b, c \in \mathbb{C}[x]$. We can easily find $p, q, r \in \mathbb{C}$ such that $(pa)^n + (qb)^n + (rc)^n = 0$. This contradicts the minimality of our choice of f, g, h . $\square$

3 Chapter 2

3.1 $\mathbb{Z}_p$ and $\mathbb{Q}_p$

Let $A_n = \mathbb{Z}/p^n\mathbb{Z}$. There is a natural projection map $\phi_n : A_n \rightarrow A_{n-1}$.

Definition 3.1. We define $\mathbb{Z}_p$ as the limit (in category of rings) of

$$\cdots \xrightarrow{\phi_{n+1}} A_n \xrightarrow{\phi_n} A_{n-1} \xrightarrow{\phi_{n-1}} \cdots \xrightarrow{\phi_2} A_1$$

By the definition, any $x \in \mathbb{Z}_p$ can be represented as a sequence $(\dots, x_2, x_1)$ where $x_n \in A_n$ and $\phi_n(x_n) = x_{n-1}$. Alternatively, we can represent x as an infinite sum

$$x = a_0 + a_1p + a_2p^2 + \cdots$$

where $a_i \in \{0, 1, \dots, p-1\}$.

We can also define the topology on $\mathbb{Z}_p$ as the induced topology from the product topology on $\prod A_n$ where A_n is given the discrete topology.

Theorem 3.2

$\mathbb{Z}_p$ is compact.

Proof. We will need a lemma from topology.

Lemma 3.3

Closed subset of a compact space is compact.

Proof. If K is compact and $F \subseteq K$ is closed, then for any open covering of F , we can add $K \setminus F$ to get an open covering of K . So there is a finite subcovering, removing $K \setminus F$ gives a finite subcovering of F . $\square$

Since $\prod A_n$ is compact by Tychonoff's theorem, it suffices to show $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is closed in $\prod A_n$. It suffices show that its complement is open. For any $y \notin \mathbb{Z}_p$, there exists some j such that $\phi_j(y_j) \neq y_{j-1}$. There exists an open set $U = \prod U_n$ where $U_n = A_n$ for $n \neq j, j-1$, $U_j = \{y_j\}$ and $U_{j-1} = \{y_{j-1}\}$. It's clear that U is an open neighborhood of y and $U \cap \mathbb{Z}_p = \emptyset$. So $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is closed. $\square$

Theorem 3.4

$$0 \rightarrow A_m \xrightarrow{\times p^n} A_{m+n} \xrightarrow{\phi_{m+n,n}} A_n \rightarrow 0$$

is an exact sequence of abelian groups.

This is easy to check. The first injective map is moving the the last m digits $\times p^n$ to the left by n places and fill the last n digits with zero, the second map is just truncating the last n digits. We will use this in $\mathbb{Z}_p$.

Theorem 3.5

$$0 \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_p \xrightarrow{\times p^n} \mathbb{Z}_p \rightarrow A_n \rightarrow 0$$

is an exact sequence of abelian groups.

Proof. First, we need to show $\mathbb{Z}_p \xrightarrow{\times p^n} \mathbb{Z}_p$ is injective. Notice that if $\phi_{m+n,n}(x_{m+n}) = x_n$, then $p^m x_n$ and $p^m x_{m+n}$ are the same in A_{m+n} . Therefore, we conclude that multiplying by p^n is just adding n zeros to the end, that is sending $(\dots, x_2, x_1)$ to $(\dots, p^n x_2, p^n x_1, 0, \dots, 0)$. Let j be the smallest integer such that the j -th digit of x is nonzero (not divisible by p^j), then the $j+n$ -th digit of $\times p^n x$ is also nonzero since it's not divisible by p^{j+n} , so the map is injective.

The image of $\times p^n$ is just $p^n \mathbb{Z}_p$, which is exactly the kernel of the projection map to A_n since the last n digits are all zero. $\square$

Theorem 3.6

Two propositions:

1. For an element $x \in \mathbb{Z}_p$ to be invertible, it is equivalent to say that it's not divisible by p , i.e., the first digit a_0 in its expansion is nonzero.
2. Let U be the group of units in $\mathbb{Z}_p$. Then we have the decomposition. For any $x \in \mathbb{Z}_p$, we can write

$$x = p^n u$$

where $n \geq 0$ and $u \in U$ in a unique way.

For part 1, if x_1 is invertible, a_i are coprime to p . By Bezout's lemma, there exists $a_i, b_i \in \mathbb{Z}$ such that $a_i x_i + b_i p^i = 1$. Let $a = (\dots, a_2, a_1)$, this is clearly the inverse of x and we can check it's indeed in $\mathbb{Z}_p$.

Other parts are easy.

Proposition 3.7

propositions of $\mathbb{Z}_p$ as rings:

1. As a ring, we can check that $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is an integral domain. In fact, it's a local ring with maximal ideal $p\mathbb{Z}_p$.
2. $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is discrete valuation ring. Thus, Euclidean domain, PID and UFD.

Definition 3.8. We define $v_p(x) = n$ if $x = p^n u$ where u is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_p$. We define $v_p(0) = +\infty$.

Proposition 3.9

$v_p(xy) = v_p(x) + v_p(y)$ and $v_p(x + y) \geq \inf\{v_p(x), v_p(y)\}$ with equality if $v_p(x) \neq v_p(y)$.

This allows us to define a metric on $\mathbb{Z}_p$ as follows:

Definition 3.10. $d(x, y) = p^{-v(x-y)}$

A notable property is that $d(x, y) = d(x - z, y - z)$ for any $x, y, z \in \mathbb{Z}_p$. So the metric is translation invariant. In particular, we have $d(x, y) = d(0, y - x)$.

Theorem 3.11

The metric space $(\mathbb{Z}_p, d)$ is homomorphic to the topological space $\mathbb{Z}_p$ defined as the subspace of $\prod A_n$ with the product topology.

Proof. It suffices to show that the identity map from $(\mathbb{Z}_p, d)$ to $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is continuous in both directions.

For any open set $U \subseteq \mathbb{Z}_p$,

$$U = \mathbb{Z}_p \cap \left(\bigcup_{i \in I} \left(\prod U_{n,i} \right) \right) = \bigcup_{i \in I} \left(\left(\prod U_{n,i} \cap \mathbb{Z}_p \right) \right)$$

where $U_{n,i} = A_n$ for all but finitely many n .

What does $T_i = \prod U_{n,i} \cap \mathbb{Z}_p$ look like? Let N be the largest integer such that $U_{N,i} \neq A_N$. Then, T_i is the set of x such that the first N digits of x are fixed and the rest can be anything possible, that is $x = (\dots, a_N, \dots, a_1)$ where $a_1, \dots, a_N$ are fixed. The preimage of T_i in $(\mathbb{Z}_p, d)$ is precisely the open ball centered at x with radius p^{-N} , that is $x + p^N \mathbb{Z}_p$.

Conversely, what does any open ball in $(\mathbb{Z}_p, d)$ look like in $\mathbb{Z}_p$? First, the open ball of 0 is just ideals $p^n \mathbb{Z}_p$. For other point, if the radius of the open ball is p^{-N} , for some $N \in \mathbb{Z}$. $d(x, y) = d(0, x - y) < p^{-N}$ means $v_p(x - y) > N$, which means the first N digits of x and y are the same. So the open balls are the cosets of $p^n \mathbb{Z}_p$. So the preimage of this open ball is the set of y such that the first N digits are fixed, which is clearly open in $\mathbb{Z}_p$. $\square$

Proposition 3.12

properties of $\mathbb{Z}_p$ as a metric space:

1. image of $d(0, x)$ is discrete in $\mathbb{R}$. So $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is totally disconnected.
2. $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is complete under this metric. This follows from the fact that $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is compact.
3. $\mathbb{Z}$ is dense in $\mathbb{Z}_p$. Just find an integer with the same first n digits as the element in $\mathbb{Z}_p$ you want to approximate.

Definition 3.13. We define $\mathbb{Q}_p$ as the field of fractions of $\mathbb{Z}_p$. Equivalently, it's the localization of $\mathbb{Z}_p$ at $U = 1, p, p^2, \dots$.

Definition 3.14. For any $x \in \mathbb{Q}_p$, we can write $x = p^n u$ where $n \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $u \in U$. We define $v_p(x) = n$ and $v_p(0) = +\infty$.

Proposition 3.15

propositions about $\mathbb{Q}_p$:

1. $x \in \mathbb{Q}_p$ is in $\mathbb{Z}_p$ iff $v_p(x) \geq 0$.
2. The metric $d(x, y) = p^{-v_p(x-y)}$ makes $\mathbb{Q}_p$ a topological field.
3. $\mathbb{Z}_p$ is a clopen subset of $\mathbb{Q}_p$.
4. $\mathbb{Q}_p$ is locally compact, that is for any $x \in \mathbb{Q}_p$, there exists open set U and compact set K such that $x \in U \subseteq K$.
5. $\mathbb{Q}$ is dense in $\mathbb{Q}_p$.

For any open neighborhood of $x \in \mathbb{Q}_p$, it looks like $x + p^n \mathbb{Z}_p$ for some n (in fact clopen). Notice that translation and scaling are homeomorphisms, so any neighborhood of x is compact. Others are easy to check.

Proposition 3.16

The metric d is an ultrametric, that is it satisfies the strong triangle inequality

$$d(x, z) \leq \max\{d(x, y), d(y, z)\}$$

for any $x, y, z \in \mathbb{Q}_p$.

As a result, $d(u_m, u_n) \leq \sup_{k \geq n} d(u_k, u_{k+1})$ for any sequence $\{u_n\}$ in $\mathbb{Q}_p$ and any $m > n$. Therefore, a sequence $\{u_n\}$ is Cauchy iff $d(u_n, u_{n+1}) \rightarrow 0$ as $n \rightarrow \infty$ iff $\lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} u_{n+1} - u_n = 0$.

3.2 p -adic equations

Lemma 3.17

Let $\cdots \rightarrow D_n \rightarrow D_{n-1} \rightarrow \cdots \rightarrow D_1$ be a projective system of non-empty finite sets. Then, the projective limit $\varprojlim D_n$ is non-empty.

Proof. If each projection map is surjective, then it's clear. So our goal is to turn each map into a surjective map. For each D_n , we define $D_{n,p}$ to be the image of D_{n+p} projected to D_n . Therefore, for a fixed n , we have a decreasing sequence of non-empty finite sets

$$D_n \supseteq D_{n,1} \supseteq D_{n,2} \supseteq \cdots$$

Since D_i is finite, there exists N such that $D_{n,N} = D_{n,N+1} = \cdots$. We define $E_n = D_{n,N}$. It's clearly that E_n is non-empty and finite. And E_n is the image

of E_{n+1} projected to D_n . So we have a projective system of non-empty finite sets with surjective projection maps. Therefore, the projective limit $\varprojlim E_n$ is non-empty. It's clear that $\varprojlim E_n \subseteq \varprojlim D_n$, so $\varprojlim D_n$ is non-empty. $\square$

Definition 3.18. If $f \in \mathbb{Z}_p[x]$ is a polynomial, for $n \geq 1$, we define $f_n \in A_n[x]$ to be the reduction of $f \bmod p^n$.

Theorem 3.19

Let S be a set of polynomials in $\mathbb{Z}_p[x_1, \dots, x_n]$. The following are equivalent:

1. There exists a common root of S in $\mathbb{Z}_p^n$.
2. For all $m \geq 1$, there exists a common root of S_m (the reduction of $S \bmod p^m$) in A_m^n .

Proof. (1) $\implies$ (2) is trivial since we can reduce the common root $\bmod p^m$ to get a common root in A_m^n .

For (2) $\implies$ (1), for each $m \geq 1$, let D_m be the set of common roots of S_m . So we have a project system of non-empty finite sets $\{D_m\}$ with projection maps induced by the natural projection $A_m \rightarrow A_{m-1}$. By the previous lemma, the projective limit $\varprojlim D_m$ is non-empty. Any element in the projective limit gives a common root of S in $\mathbb{Z}_p^n$. $\square$

Definition 3.20. $x = (x_1, \dots, x_n) \in (\mathbb{Z}_p)^n$ is called primitive if one of x_i is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_p$. One can similarly define primitive elements in $(A_n)^n$.

Theorem 3.21

Let S be a set of homogeneous polynomials in $\mathbb{Z}_p[x_1, \dots, x_n]$. The following are equivalent:

1. S has a non trivial common root in $\mathbb{Q}_p^n$.
2. There exists a common primitive root of S in $\mathbb{Z}_p^n$.
3. For all $m \geq 1$, there exists a common primitive root of S_m (the reduction of $S \bmod p^m$) in A_m^n .

This is easy to check.

Lemma 3.22 (Hensel's Lemma)

Let $f \in \mathbb{Z}_p[x]$ be a polynomial. Let $a \in \mathbb{Z}_p$, $n, k \in \mathbb{Z}$ such that $0 \leq 2k < n$, $f(a) \equiv 0 \pmod{p^n}$ and $v_p(f'(a)) = k$. Then, there exists a $b \in \mathbb{Z}_p$ such that $f(b) \equiv 0 \pmod{p^{n+1}}$, $v_p(f'(b)) = k$ and $b \equiv a \pmod{p^{n-k}}$.

Our familiar version is the case when $k = 0$ and $n = 1$.

Proof. Take $b = a + p^{n-k}z$ with $z \in \mathbb{Z}_p$ so that $a \equiv b \pmod{p^{n-k}}$.

$$f(b) = f(a + p^{n-k}z) = f(a) + p^{n-k}zf'(a) + p^{2n-2k}z^2t + \dots$$

Therefore, let $f'(a) = p^k c$ and $f(a) = p^n r$, we have

$$f(b) \equiv p^n r + p^n zc \pmod{p^{n+1}}$$

Note that the second term is suppose to be $(p^{2n-2k}z^2)\frac{f''(a)}{2}$, so where is the $\frac{1}{2}$? This is a real problem if $p = 2$ The answer is that when we expand $f(a + x)$, all coefficients of x^2 should automatically be in $\mathbb{Z}_p$, so $f''(a)$ is divisible by 2. And here we denote $t = \frac{f''(a)}{2}$

Since $p \nmid c$, we can find z such that $r + zc \equiv 0 \pmod{p}$. Lastly, we can easily check that $f'(b) = f'(a + p^{n-k}z) \equiv f'(a) \pmod{p^{n-k}}$, so $v_p(f'(b)) = k$. $\square$

Remark 3.23. Notice that we can do this iteratively to get a solution $y \in \mathbb{Z}_p$ such that $f(y) = 0$ and $y \equiv a \pmod{p^{n-k}}$.

Theorem 3.24 (Generalization of Hensel's Lemma)

Let $f \in \mathbb{Z}_p[x_1, \dots, x_m]$ be a polynomial. Let $a = (a_1, \dots, a_m) \in (\mathbb{Z}_p)^m$, $n, k \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $1 \leq j \leq m$ such that $0 \leq 2k < n$, $f(a) \equiv 0 \pmod{p^n}$ and $v_p\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}(a)\right) = k$.

Then there exists $y \in \mathbb{Z}_p^m$ such that $f(y) = 0$ and $y \equiv a \pmod{p^{n-k}}$.

Proof. When $m = 1$ is just Hensel's lemma.

If $m > 1$, we can plug in $x_i = a_i$ for all $i \neq j$ and consider the polynomial $g(x_j) = f(a_1, \dots, a_{j-1}, x_j, a_{j+1}, \dots, a_m)$. It's clear that $g(a_j) \equiv 0 \pmod{p^n}$ and $v_p(g'(a_j)) = v_p\left(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}(a)\right) = k$. So by Hensel's lemma, there exists $y_j \in \mathbb{Z}_p$ such that $g(y_j) = 0$ and $y_j \equiv a_j \pmod{p^{n-k}}$. Thus, $y = (a_1, \dots, a_{j-1}, y_j, a_{j+1}, \dots, a_m)$ is the desired solution and $y \equiv a \pmod{p^{n-k}}$. $\square$

Corollary 3.25

Here are three useful special cases:

1. If $a \in (\mathbb{Z}_p)^m$ such that $f(a) \equiv 0 \pmod{p}$ and there exists $1 \leq j \leq m$ such that $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}(a)$ is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_p$, then there exists $y \in (\mathbb{Z}_p)^m$ such that $f(y) = 0$ and $y \equiv a \pmod{p}$. This is the case when $n = 1$ and $k = 0$.
2. Suppose $p \neq 2$, let $f(x) = \sum_{i,j} a_{ij}x_i x_j$ with $a_{ij} = a_{ji} \in \mathbb{Z}_p$. If $\det(a_{ij})$ is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_p$ and there exists a non-zero solution $r \in (\mathbb{Z}/p\mathbb{Z})^n$ such that $f(r) \equiv t \pmod{p}$ for some $t \in \mathbb{Z}_p$, then there exists a non-trivial solution $y \in (\mathbb{Z}_p)^n$ such that $f(y) = t$ and $y \equiv r \pmod{p}$.

This is special case of (1). To prove it, we simply need to verify there exists $1 \leq j \leq n$ such that $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}(r)$ is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_p$. Notice that

$$\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_i}(r) = 2 \sum_j a_{ij} r_j$$

The vector $(\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_1}(r), \dots, \frac{\partial f}{\partial x_n}(r))$ is just $2Ar$ where $A = (a_{ij})$. Since $\det(A)$ is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_p$, A is invertible over $\mathbb{Z}/p\mathbb{Z}$. Since r is non-trivial, Ar is also non-trivial, so at least one of its coordinates is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_p$.

3. If $p = 2$, let $f(x) = \sum_{i,j} a_{ij}x_i x_j$ with $a_{ij} = a_{ji} \in \mathbb{Z}_2$. If $\det(a_{ij})$ is a unit in $\mathbb{Z}_2$ and there exists a non-zero solution $r \in (\mathbb{Z}/8\mathbb{Z})^n$ such that $f(r) \equiv t \pmod{8}$ for some $t \in \mathbb{Z}_2$ and $\frac{\partial f}{\partial x_j}(r) \not\equiv 0 \pmod{4}$, then there exists a non-trivial solution $y \in (\mathbb{Z}_2)^n$ such that $f(y) = t$ and $y \equiv r \pmod{8}$. This is the case when $n = 3$ and $k = 1$. The proof is similar to (2).